

PTI

THE **SPORTSWOMEN**

Captain on the Charge

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Salima's journey from a remote village to hockey captaincy shows Indian sports at its best—talent emerging from regions far from elite systems

Growing up in Simdega, Salima was the toast of her village, Barki Chhapar, for the number of goats and chickens she'd regularly win for her exploits with the stick at local tournaments. These days, she has settled for medals and accolades. The recent bounty includes the Arjuna Award and a silver medal at the Asia Cup in 2025.

Salima picked up the sport inspired by her farmer father, Sulakshan, a local player. "I would go with him to tournaments and learned by looking at him," she says. It's why 'papa' is still her biggest inspiration. Her family and villagers' support, she says, was crucial too. "Girls were never stopped from playing. My dream was always to play for India." That ambition got fast wheels under the tutelage of late Pratima Barwa at Simdega training centre. She made her debut for the national senior team in 2017. Salima has proven how sport can empower women. With her father the sole breadwinner, Salima's prowess in hockey since the youth level has helped the family considerably. In doing so, the speedy, attacking midfielder nicknamed 'the Ferrari' soon became an icon for other young women, especially those from tribal backgrounds.

HER ADVICE

"Women can do it all. So, never give up. I also think that having parental support is necessary. Share what you feel with them"

Only 22 when she took over the reins as captain in 2024, Salima has quickly adapted to the role. She credits her teammates as well as erstwhile captains Rani Rampal and Savita for their leadership. Already a veteran of the squad at 24, Salima has experienced several setbacks—narrowly missing out on a medal at Tokyo 2020 and failing to qualify for the 2024 Paris Games. However, her maiden Olympics remains a personal turning point. "My life and the situation at home became better with it," she says. Her next goal is to win gold at the upcoming Asian Games to qualify for the 2028 LA Games. A podium finish there would be an enduring achievement. ■

— Suhani Singh